

Rationalism

The rationalist movement, popular in early 20th-century Italy, arose out of a belief that successful architecture can be interpreted by reason. In 1926, a group of young architects including Guido Frette (1901–84) Adalberto Libera (1903–63) and Giuseppe Terragni (1904–43) founded Gruppo 7 and published a manifesto in the magazine *Rassegna Italiana*, declaring: 'We do not intend to break with tradition ... The new architecture, the true architecture, should be the result of a close association between logic and rationality.' Spurning useless ornamentation, they embraced the machine age (albeit less violently than their futurist compatriots), and were inspired by the modernist essays of Le Corbusier and Gropius. They also, however, sought to create a timeless Italian architecture. The results could be jarring: the corner of Terragni's Novocomum in Como (1927–9, opposite) featured a squared-off top floor atop a curved, glazed shaft. But they could also work effectively, as in Libera's Trento Elementary School (1931–3), whose modern lines sat comfortably with the ancient city wall.

